

this in the last few weeks. When Prime Minister Manmohan Singh arrived in Raichur, most of the disaster management team was being monitored by Karandlaje though it functions under Revenue Minister Karunakara Reddy. A furious Karunakara could hardly hide his anger as Karandlaje flashed her political power. Karunakara shared his woes with his younger brother Janardhan, the strategist in the family. Karnataka's lone woman

MP J. Shantha also publicly accused Karandlaje of being the root of the current political crisis.

While Yeddyurappa's dependence on Karandlaje during the flood relief sparked off the slugfest, it was only an excuse for other Yeddyurappa-baiters to jump onto the Reddy bandwagon. When Karunakara was not consulted by Yeddyurappa when the latter roped in businessman and Rajya Sabha member Rajeev Chandra-

shekhar to head a private-public partnership project to relocate flood hit villages in north Karnataka, the Reddy brothers declared war. On November 3 in Bangalore, Karunakara said, "My officials can handle all flood relief assignments and there is no need for outside help."

Thanks to the mining barons' resources, over 50 MLAs are camping in hotels in Hyderabad and Goa at the brothers' cost. Janardhan, the 42-year-old MLC, wants Yeddyurappa to be replaced by Speaker Jagadish Shettar. Shettar's camp says that Yeddyurappa had promised to induct him into the Cabinet within six months of the BJP coming to power in May 2008, but that has not yet happened. As Speaker, Shettar has not spoken in public. In a compromise formula, he may end up in the Cabinet soon with Yeddyurappa dumping Karandlaje. Principal Secretary V.P. Baligar, a Lingayat officer close to the chief minister, may also be transferred.

The one edge that Karandlaje has over others is her proximity to the RSS, the BJP's big brother. She had embraced the RSS's philosophy at a young age, starting out as a worker and slowly working her way up as a BJP office-bearer under the watchful patronage of Yeddyurappa. She was also an ABVP activist in her youth and worked with the Mahila Morcha, which attracted her to the state BJP leadership, under Yeddyurappa's control at that time. Her first break came when she was appointed general secretary of the party.

She rose quickly in the state BJP, thanks to Yeddyurappa who made her in-charge of the by-election in Ullal in Mangalore district where the BJP lost. Yeddyurappa then planted her in Bangalore to contest from Yeshwantapura. She won and was included in the Cabinet on the grounds that she was representing women. She then became in-charge of Mysore

KARANDLAJE WITH YEDDYURAPPA
(LEFT); KARUNAKARA,
JANARDHAN AND SRIRAMULU



THE REDDYS WANT THE ASSEMBLY SPEAKER TO REPLACE YEDDYURAPPA.